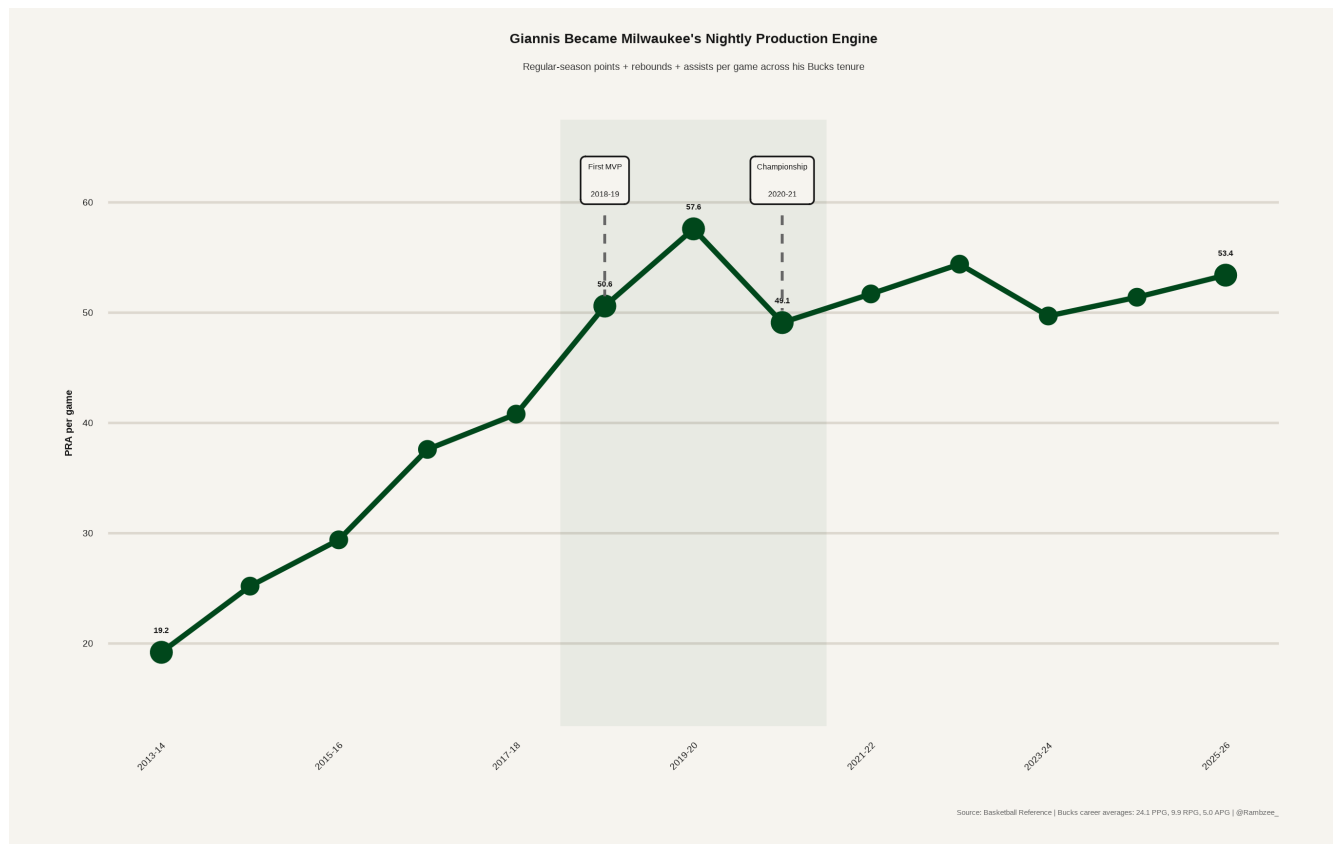


The Milwaukee Bucks Post-Giannis

The end of the Giannis era

Five years removed from their second title in franchise history, and 13 years after drafting the player who came to define their modern era, the Milwaukee Bucks officially moved on from Giannis Antetokounmpo. It is unusual for a player who became the center of a franchise's identity to be moved in the midst of his prime. He arrived as a raw teenager, grew into an MVP, gave the Bucks a title, and turned a small-market team into one of the league's defining programs of the decade. Over the last 10 years, only Boston (530) and Denver (495) have won more regular-season games than Milwaukee (486). For a franchise that had spent most of the previous four decades fielding deeply talented, beloved teams that just could not break through, Giannis became the ultimate validator.

The ending makes that greatness easy to forget. The last few seasons were an undeniable mess: the Damian Lillard acquisition never clicked the way Milwaukee needed, the organization churned through a midseason coaching change, and Khris Middleton's ill-timed injuries eventually led to him being moved for Kyle Kuzma. Suddenly, the old core stopped looking like a clear-cut contender and more like a team that needed everything to break perfectly to make a run. Eventually, the Bucks simply ran out of answers.

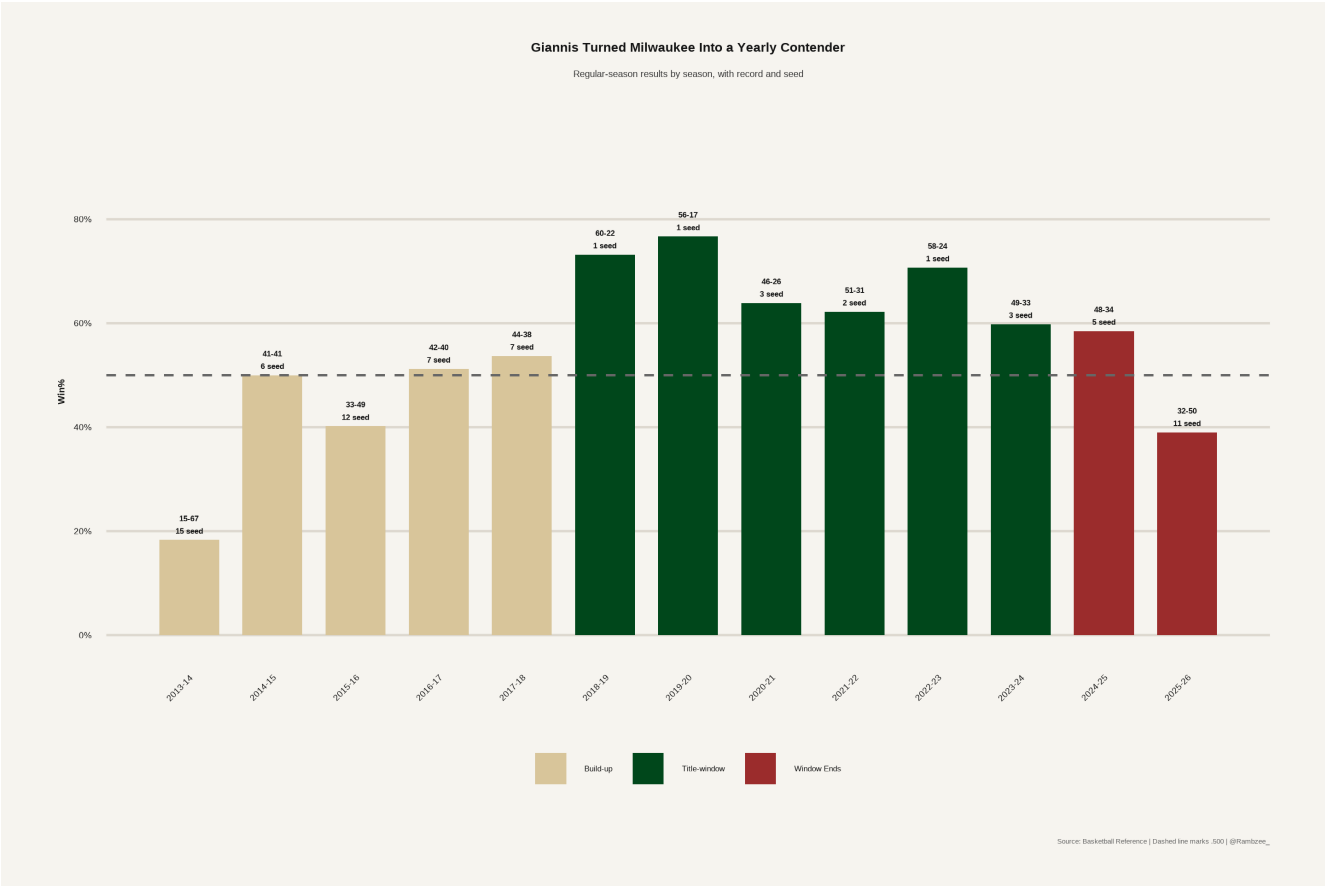


Giannis' Milwaukee Résumé		
The case for the greatest Buck ever is not complicated		
Accomplishment	Count	Context
TEAM ACCOMPLISHMENTS		
Championships	1	2021
NBA Cup Championships	1	2024
MAJOR AWARDS		
MVPs	2	2018-19 and 2019-20
Finals MVPs	1	2021
Defensive Player of the Year	1	2019-20
Most Improved Player	1	2016-17
NBA Cup MVP	1	2024
ALL-LEAGUE RECOGNITION		
All-Star selections	10	
All-NBA selections	9	7x First Team, 2x Second Team
All-Defense selections	5	4x First Team, 1x Second Team
SCORING AND PLAYOFF PRODUCTION		
25+ PPG seasons	9	2017-18 through 2025-26
Playoff series wins	8	
Playoff wins	44	
40-point games	64	56 regular season, 8 playoffs
50-point games	10	9 regular season, 1 playoffs
60-point games	1	1 regular season

That résumé is why the messy ending should not diminish the whole story. Milwaukee did not waste the Giannis era. The Bucks won the title, spent years with a real chance to win more, and made the kind of aggressive choices a franchise should make around a player like Giannis. The problem is that those choices still came with a cost.

The Cost of Climbing That High

The Bucks pushed all their chips in around Antetokounmpo, chasing upgrades at the cost of picks, money, flexibility, and future optionality because the present was too big of an opportunity to treat carefully.



For a long time, that urgency was rewarded. Milwaukee became one of the league’s most bankable regular-season teams, winning at a level that made contention feel like a given year after year.

The Playoff Ceiling Closed Quickly After the Title				
Milwaukee won the championship in 2021, then never got back past Round 2				
Season	Result	Opponent	Series	What It Meant
2016-17	R1 Loss	Raptors	2-4	First playoff taste of the Giannis era
2017-18	R1 Loss	Celtics	3-4	Still building around the rising star
2018-19	ECF Loss	Raptors	2-4	First true title-level team
2019-20	R2 Loss	Heat	1-4	Elite regular season did not translate in the bubble
2020-21	Won	Suns	4-2	Title breakthrough
2021-22	R2 Loss	Celtics	3-4	Middleton injury changed the ceiling
2022-23	R1 Loss	Heat	1-4	58-win team, but cracks showed
2023-24	R1 Loss	Pacers	2-4	Giannis injury, Dame era never stabilized
2024-25	R1 Loss	Pacers	1-4	Dame Achilles, window effectively closed

However, regular-season credibility and playoff certainty are not the same thing. After the 2021 championship, Milwaukee still looked poised to compete, but the foundation quickly started to erode. Middleton’s knee injury closed the door on the repeat bid. The 2023 collapse against Miami cracked the confidence and pushed the Bucks toward another desperate swing. Giannis’ 2024 injury wrecked the first Dame postseason. Dame’s Achilles ended the last version of the chase.

After the title, the Bucks never made it back past Round 2.

The Moves That Built and Ended the Giannis Era			
Milwaukee's Giannis era moved from discovery, to title spending, to one last scramble before the resetting			
Year	Move	Phase	Why It Mattered
2013	Drafted Giannis Antetokounmpo	Foundation	The swing that changed the franchise.
2013	Acquired Khris Middleton	Foundation	The eventual co-star arrived around the same time.
2017	Traded for Eric Bledsoe	First push	Milwaukee started spending around Giannis.
2018	Signed Brook Lopez	Core build	Lopez gave the title core its spacing and defensive backbone.
2020	Signed Bobby Portis	Title build	A low-cost signing became a major part of the team's identity.
2020	Traded for Jrue Holiday	Title build	The all-in move that pushed them over the top.
2021	Won the championship	Peak	The payoff for years of aggressive building.
2023	Traded for Damian Lillard	Final swing	Milwaukee moved off Jrue to pair Dame and Giannis.
2025	Moved Khris Middleton for Kyle Kuzma	Core breaks	The original title core no longer intact.
2025	Waived Damian Lillard and signed Myles Turner	Scramble	The retool turned into a scramble.
2026	Traded Giannis Antetokounmpo	Reset	The era officially ended.
2026	Drafted Brayden Burries and Nate Ament	Reset	The next timeline started with two lottery picks.

The path required a lot of sacrifice, and not every move aged the same. Some contributed to the ultimate moment. Others helped box Milwaukee into the reset it faces now. But the tradeoff is not hard to understand. The Bucks won the championship, stayed relevant for more than a decade, and got the greatest run the franchise has had since Kareem.

That does not make the current situation any less uncomfortable.

Milwaukee's Awkward Middle Ground

Milwaukee's position is precarious as the Bucks do not fully control their own first-round pick until 2031, so losing does not come with the usual reward. Veterans from the title chase still occupy roster spots, and the youngest players are not ready to inherit the team by default. There are prospects worth investing in, but no obvious centerpiece yet. Milwaukee has to sell development without the comfort of a blank slate.

The Pick Situation Is Still Bleak			
Miami adds upside, but Milwaukee remains without clear control of its own first until 2031			
Year	1st-Round Control	2nd-Round Control	Read
2027	No clear control	Outgoing second	Old obligations still limit the bottom-out path
2028	No clear control	Outgoing second	Old obligations still limit the bottom-out path
2029	No clear control	Outgoing second	Old obligations still limit the bottom-out path
2030	Partial upside	Outgoing second	Miami upside starts to matter, but control is still partial
2031	Incoming first; Clear own first	Outgoing second	Incoming Miami first plus own first creates opportunity
2032	Clear own first	Outgoing second	Clean own first, but no extra Miami first
2033	Incoming first; Clear own first	Two seconds	Incoming Miami first plus own first creates opportunity

The next few seasons are less about the record than the answers the Bucks can pull from an awkward roster. The Bucks need to give real runway to the young players, reroute veterans where it makes sense, and find out whether anyone starts to play like part of the next core.

The Miami picks do not fix that problem, but they make it easier to navigate. The 2030 swap gives Milwaukee another upside lever before it regains full control of its own first-rounders, while the unprotected 2031 and 2033 firsts give them real draft capital beyond internal development.

What Milwaukee Got From Miami

The Miami return is not the ideal handoff to the next era, but it gave Milwaukee several different ways to start sorting the roster after Giannis. Herro is the clear short-term scorer and likely the easiest player to reroute later. Jaquez gives them a sturdier wing with feel, cutting, slashing, and matchup attacking. Ware is the higher-ceiling frontcourt swing, while Kasparas gives the Bucks another guard whose value is tied to shooting and processing. The picks matter too, but the immediate question is how much Milwaukee can get from the players attached to them.

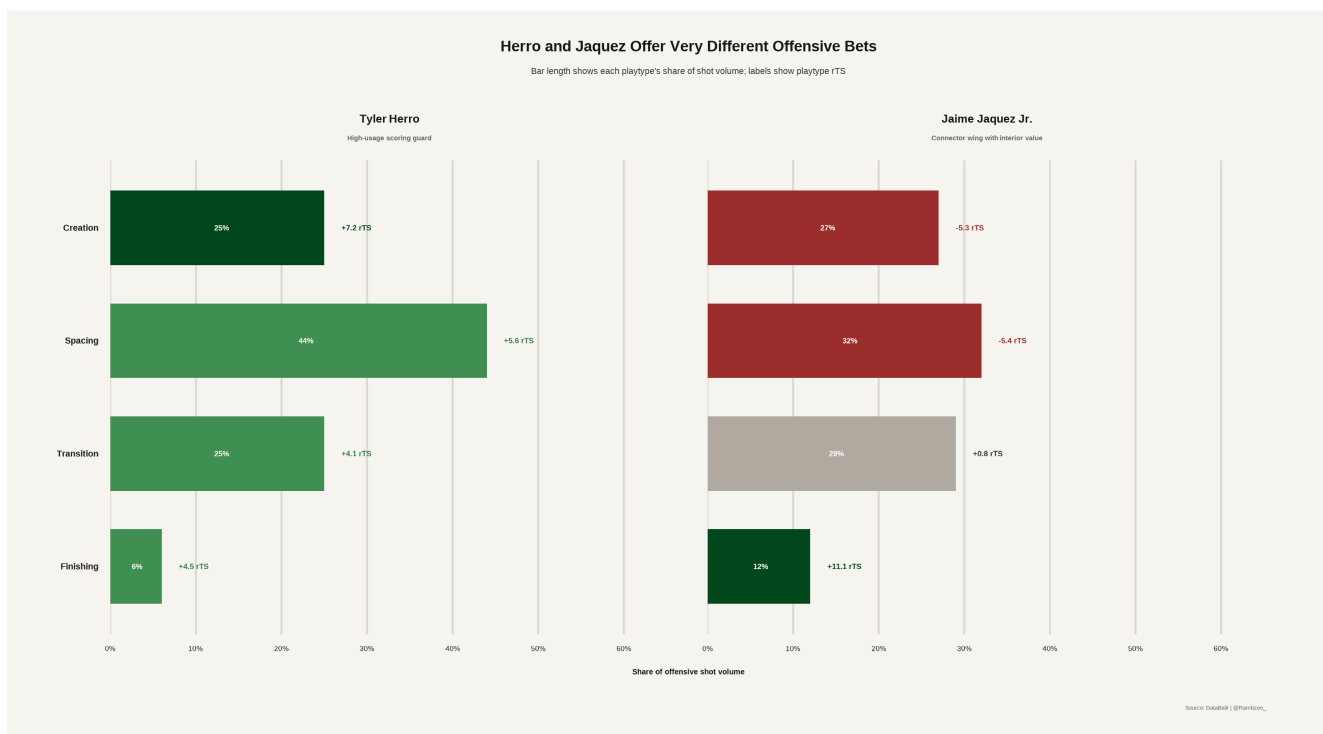
What Milwaukee Got From Miami				
Scoring, connective play, frontcourt upside, guard skill, and draft capital				
Player	Age	Pos	Last Season	Main Question
Jaime Jaquez Jr.	25.3	SF	15.4 PPG, 5.0 RPG, 4.7 APG (57.0 TS%)	How does he fit into this balance of youth and contributing players?
Kasparas Jakucionis	20.1	PG	6.2 PPG, 2.6 RPG, 2.6 APG, 17.8 MPG (61.4 TS%)	Can he become an actual advantage creator, not just a shooter/passer?
Kel'e'l Ware	22.2	C	11.1 PPG, 9.0 RPG (2.8 ORPG), 0.7 APG (61.6 TS%)	Can the motor, strength, and defensive consistency catch up to the tools?
Tyler Herro	26.4	SG	20.5 PPG, 4.8 RPG, 4.1 APG (60.2 TS%)	Is he part of the next core or the next player moved?

Herro and Jaquez can help right away, though both may eventually be more valuable as flexible pieces than roster main-stays. Ware and Kasparas need more runway, but they are closer to the kind of upside Milwaukee needs.

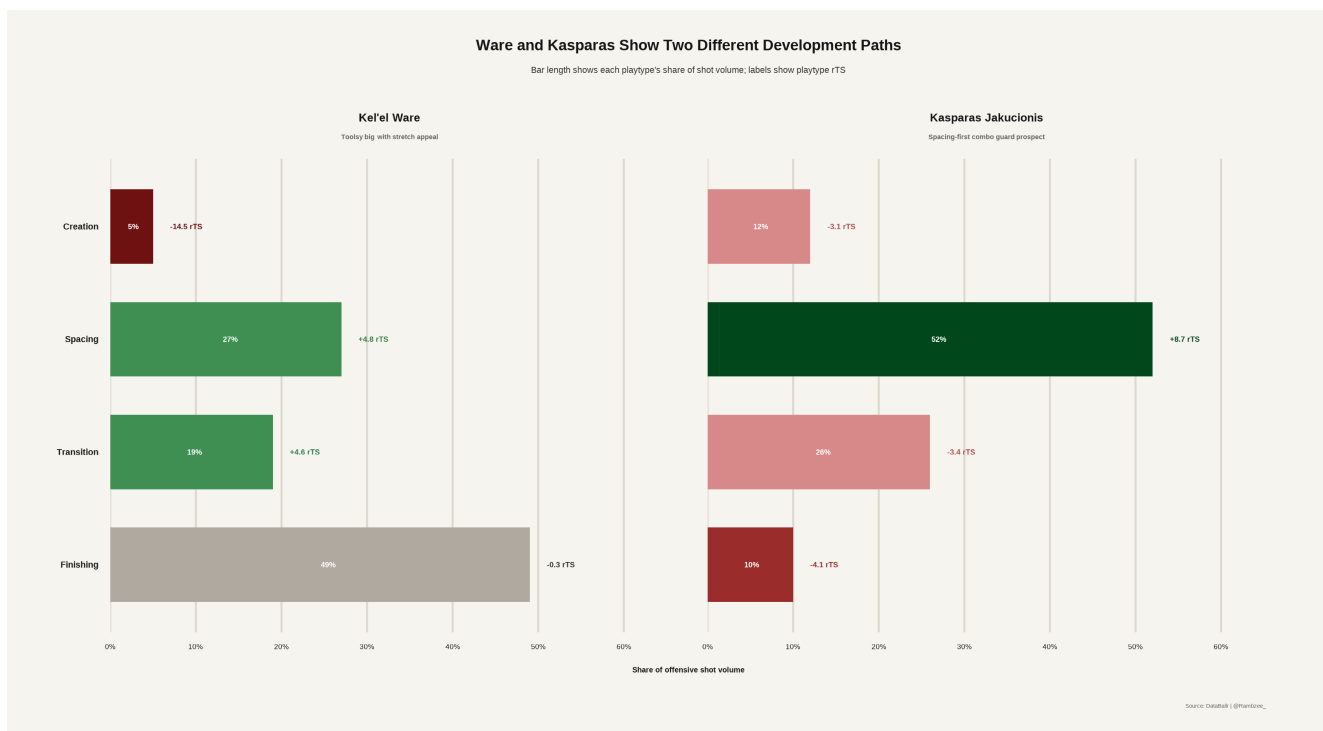
The Cleanest Skill Signal Is Shooting					
3-point rate and 3-point percentage, with positional percentile ranks					
Player	3Pr	3Pr %ile	3P%	3P% %ile	Read
Tyler Herro	0.43	26	37.8	64	Known volume spacer
Kasparas Jakucionis	0.66	93	42.3	98	Best shooting signal in the return
Kel'e'l Ware	0.36	88	39.5	88	Rare spacing indicator for a young big
Jaime Jaquez Jr.	0.20	3	31.7	20	Main shooting swing question
Source: DataBallr Percentile ranks are based on positional-ranked percentiles.					

Shooting is the clearest shared thread. Herro is a proven volume spacer. Kasparas has the loudest pure shooting signal. Ware's shooting is unusual for his size, but the indicators are clear enough to project him as a viable spacing big. Jaquez is the exception, with low 3-point volume and shaky percentages.

Milwaukee already had the outline of a high-volume shooting team. The Bucks ranked 10th in 3-point attempts last season at 39.1 per game, fifth in 3-point frequency at 45.7%, and second in accuracy at 38.7%. Adding Kasparas and Ware to Rollins, AJ Green, and the young spacers they drafted gives Milwaukee a clear identity to test while the rest of the roster gets sorted out.



Herro and Jaquez bring different kinds of offensive value. Herro gives Milwaukee scalable scoring through creation, spacing, and off-ball shooting gravity. Jaquez is more connective, but not incidental. His slashing, passing, transition play, and mismatch attacking were strong enough to put him in the Sixth Man of the Year conversation. The swing point is shooting gravity. Herro bends defenses from the perimeter. Jaquez generates immense downhill pressure, but he has to keep defenses honest for that value to scale as he draws more attention.



Ware and Kasparas are the longer developmental pieces, but the hope is not just that they become playable. Ware is the biggest swing; if the shooting, rebounding, and rim protection all click, he can become a starting-level frontcourt piece with real two-way value. Kasparas gets there differently. His value depends on the shooting and processing

translating well enough for him to become a useful rotation connector without being held back by his athletic limitations.

DataBallr Snapshot: Miami Return											
Selected impact, shooting, creation, and frontcourt indicators											
Player	DPM	O-DPM	D-DPM	Shots	rTS	3Pr	3P%	PotAst	On-Ball	DRB%	BLK
Tyler Herro	0.6	1.8	-1.3	25.7	2.3	0.4	37.8	10.2	20.1	13.4	0.6
Jaime Jaquez Jr.	-0.5	0.1	-0.6	22.1	-0.6	0.2	31.7	14.8	25.4	11.3	0.5
Kel'el Ware	-0.1	0.3	-0.3	19.0	3.7	0.4	39.5	1.9	6.1	24.2	2.3
Kasparas Jakucionis	0.2	-0.2	0.4	13.0	3.2	0.7	42.3	11.2	15.8	0.2	0.3

The broader analytical profile makes that divide clearer. Ware is already showing indicators, with a 39.5% mark from three, a 24.2% defensive rebounding rate, and 2.3 blocks per 100. That is the outline of a starting-level spacing big if the tools connect. The concern is how narrow the offensive pathway can get. His 1.9 potential assists per 100 is not shocking for a big in his mold, but it shows how much of his value still has to come from finishing, spacing, rebounding, and defense. When the effort or consistency wavers, there are not many connective skills to fall back on.

Kasparas' case is cleaner on-ball. The 42.3% mark from three and 11.2 potential assists per 100 point to a guard who can shoot, process, and organize offense. He does not have Ware's physical margin for error, so those offensive skills have to translate quickly enough for him to hold a real rotation role.

The Bucks First Lottery Picks Since 2016

The Miami return was not the only way Milwaukee added young talent. The Bucks also brought in their first lottery picks since Thon Maker in 2016 with Burries and Ament.

The Lottery Swings									
Burries brings immediate impact and transition scoring; Ament is the higher-variance ceiling bet									
Player	Type	PPG	RPG	APG	TOV	2FG%	3FG%	FT%	Mock
Brayden Burries	Two-way combo guard	16.1	4.9	2.4	1.5	56.2%	39.1%	80.5%	#10 ESPN, #9 Ringer, #9 CBS
Nate Ament	Big shooting wing upside	16.7	6.3	2.3	2.3	43.0%	33.3%	79.0%	#9 ESPN, #10 Ringer, #11 CBS

Burries is the more win-now prospect. His guard size, downhill scoring, transition pressure, and defensive tools give Milwaukee a direct path to useful two-way minutes next to Ryan Rollins. He does not need the offense built around him to matter. He can find the ball, push pace, create advantages before the defense is set, and make enough winning plays to fit on a roster still searching for structure.

Ament is the project. Milwaukee needed a forward swing with size, movement, and shot-making, and he gives them that. The concern is how much has to catch up. The finishing, efficiency, processing, and physical consistency are still developing, which leaves a real gap between the idea of Ament and the current version. Still, that is the kind of gamble the Bucks needed. Safe rotation players help steady the ship, but they do not lift a team out of mediocrity. Milwaukee needed a swing at higher-end talent, and in the late lottery, that usually means living with a project.

What Milwaukee Has to Sort Out Next

The hard part now is that Milwaukee has too many timelines on one roster. Herro and Jaquez can help right away. Ware, Kasparas, Burries, and Ament need time. Rollins and Green sit somewhere in between: young enough to keep investing in, but useful enough that their trade value still has to be monitored. Rollins feels more like a piece Milwaukee should try to build with. Green is the kind of shooter contenders tend to inquire about.

The Contract Sheet Impacts the Reset

Data: Spotrac | Turner, Kuzma, and Herro are potential trade pieces.

Player	Age	2026 Salary	Years Left	Future Money	Total Left	Status
Tyler Herro	26.4	\$33M	1 year		\$33M	Expiring
Jaime Jaquez Jr.	25.3	\$5.9M	1 year		\$5.9M	Expiring
Kel'el Ware	22.2	\$4.7M	2 years	\$7.1M	\$11.8M	Team option
Brayden Burries	20.8	\$6.4M	4 years		\$6.4M	Rookie scale
Nate Ament	19.5	\$5.5M	4 years		\$5.5M	Rookie scale
Ryan Rollins	24.0	\$4M	2 years	\$4M	\$8M	Player option
AJ Green	26.7	\$10M	4 years	\$35M	\$45M	None
Andre Jackson Jr.	24.6	\$2.4M	2 years		\$2.4M	Club option
Myles Turner	30.2	\$26.6M	3 years	\$57M	\$83.6M	None
Kyle Kuzma	30.9	\$20.5M	1 year		\$20.5M	Expiring
Kevin Porter Jr.	26.1	\$5.4M	1 year		\$5.4M	Expiring
Gary Harris	31.8	\$3.8M	1 year		\$3.8M	Expiring
Jericho Sims	27.6	\$2.8M	1 year		\$2.8M	Expiring

The veteran group should be treated more like movable pieces than mainstays. Turner can provide starter minutes, but his contract and uneven 2026 season make him a logical reroute piece if the right market develops. Kuzma, Porter, Trent, Harris, and Sims are less about the next core than salary, depth, and deadline flexibility. Milwaukee should not dump veterans just to get younger; there is value in keeping established professionals around a young roster. But that stability cannot come at the cost of the evaluations the Bucks actually need to make.

That is the task of the first post-Giannis season. Milwaukee needs clearer answers on Herro's market, Jaquez's fit, Rollins' staying power, Green's value, and which of Ware, Kasparas, Burries, and Ament deserve developmental priority.

Where That Leaves Milwaukee

This is the cost of the last era. Milwaukee paid heavily to build around Giannis, and some of those swings eventually boxed the franchise in. The pick situation is bleak, the roster is awkward, and there is no obvious next star, but the Bucks are not walking into a helpless era. Without Turner and Kuzma, Milwaukee's average age drops to 24.6, which would be in the range of the league's youngest teams by raw age. That does not make this a simple rebuild, but it shows why there is room for optimism. The Bucks have young players worth evaluating, a scorer with market value, veterans who can still be moved, and two lottery swings in Burries and Ament.

It is bittersweet more than hopeless. Milwaukee is losing arguably the greatest player it ever had, but it is not walking away from the Giannis era with regret. The Bucks got thirteen years of an all-time great, their best stretch of modern relevance, and the second championship in franchise history. Most teams would take that deal and deal with the aftermath later.

Later is here now, and the next version of the Bucks will be shaped by how quickly they turn this awkward roster into one with a clearer direction.